

CORE FORMULA

You [specific action] despite [friction/constraint], and that [impact/choice] matters. -> You kept this moving even with unclear inputs, and that made the decision easier. -> You came back to the conversation instead of avoiding it, and I appreciate that. -> You held back from escalating when it was tense, and that took discipline. -> I noticed the effort. That mattered because it made the next step clearer. -> That took effort. I see it.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Name the one effort you can actually see, in a single sentence, before you move to feedback or the next task: "That took effort. I see it."

BEST FOR

- Someone brings work, a draft, an attempt, an apology, or a difficult update, and the result is imperfect but the process involved genuine effort.
- A person has done invisible setup work, care work, emotional labour, or coordination that could go unseen.
- You need to give feedback without erasing the work behind the current version.
- A team member has stayed disciplined under pressure, or a conflict de-escalates because someone showed restraint.
- A friend or partner has been trying, even if the situation is still unresolved.
- A person returns after a setback, mistake, embarrassment, or interruption.
- High standards need to coexist with recognition, so the person does not have to fight to be seen first.

PHRASE BANK

Minimum viable · Short, grounded openers

- "That took effort. I see it."
- "I can see the work behind this."
- "You did not just wing this; you put time into it."
- "Before we move on, I want to acknowledge the effort here."
- "That was not nothing. I noticed."

Professional · Work and meeting contexts

- "You clearly did the hard part of gathering the details before bringing this here."
- "I can see the preparation in how you framed the options."
- "You made the messy part easier for the rest of us to evaluate."
- "The draft still needs tightening, but the groundwork is strong."
- "You carried a lot of the setup work on this, and it made the rest easier."
- "You did the thinking before you brought it to the room."

Digital / written · Messages and documents

- "Thanks for laying this out clearly. I can see the work you put into making it easy to respond to."
- "The structure helped. You did the thinking before asking for input."
- "I appreciate the care in the way you wrote this."
- "You made the decision easier by summarising the moving parts."
- "You framed the trade-offs so we could actually decide. That took work."

Feedback without erasure · Keeping the standard intact

- "I want to recognise the work first, then talk about the revision."

- "There is visible effort here. The next step is making the argument cleaner."
- "You stayed with the hard part. Now let's make the outcome match the effort."
- "This is not finished yet, but the effort is clear."
- "The effort is real, and the next version still needs work. Let's keep both true."
- "I can see the labour here; let's put it into a sharper recommendation."

Social and relational · Friends, partners, sustained effort

- "You have been trying to handle this carefully. That matters."
- "I know this has taken a lot more energy than it looks from the outside."
- "You kept showing up for it, even when it was not giving much back."
- "That was a lot to carry, and I do not want to skip over that."
- "You have been trying to hold this together for a while. That is not nothing."

Conflict and repair · Restraint and re-entry

- "I noticed you slowed down instead of escalating. I appreciate that effort."
- "You came back to this conversation after it got awkward. That matters."
- "It took something to say that directly. I hear the effort behind it."
- "You made an effort to repair this rather than just move on. I see that."
- "You chose your words when it was tense. That helped keep this workable."

Under pressure · Constraint and discipline

- "Under that pressure, staying with the process took discipline."
- "You kept the work moving in a difficult window. I want to recognise that."
- "You had limited time and still made this usable. That effort matters."
- "You absorbed a lot of ambiguity and still brought something concrete."
- "You stayed steady when it would have been easier to drop it."

When you might be over-reading · Tentative, checkable recognition

- "It looks like there was a lot of work behind this - am I reading that right?"
- "I may be over-reading it, but I did want to recognise the effort I saw."
- "I do not want to make a big production of it; I just noticed the work."
- "Tell me if I am misreading it, but it seems like you put a lot into this."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Good job.

Better: I can see you worked on this.

Best: I can see you organised a messy set of inputs before drafting. The structure needs tightening, but the groundwork is real.

2. Weak: At least you're trying.

Better: You have been trying hard.

Best: You have kept showing up for this even when it has been draining. I do not want to skip over that.

3. Weak: I appreciate the effort, but...

Better: I see the effort, and we still need to improve the result.

Best: I want to keep two truths separate: you put real work into the outreach, and the conversion result still needs a different approach.

4. Weak: Thanks for not blowing up.

Better: I noticed you stayed calm.

Best: I noticed you paused and chose your words when it was tense. That helped keep the conversation workable.

DECISION TREE

If The effort is unclear or you would be guessing

Do not assert it. Check first, or use another package.

"It looks like there may be a lot behind this. Am I reading that right?"

If Effort is real but the outcome is imperfect

Separate effort from outcome and keep both true.

"The effort is real, and the next version still needs work."

If Effort is real and the outcome is fine

Acknowledge briefly and continue.

"I can see the preparation here."

If The person is emotionally activated

Pair it with emotional labelling or validation before any feedback.

"This sounds draining, and you have still been trying to handle it carefully."

If A power or status gap could make it sound patronising

Keep it concrete, brief, and non-performative.

"I appreciate the preparation here."

If The effort is unsustainable or unfair

Do not stop at words. Name it and change the conditions.

"I appreciate the work, and this should not require that much lift every time."

SCENARIOS

Rough draft after a difficult week

Separate the setup labour from the final polish. — "I can see the groundwork. The next version still needs tightening."

Friend trying to cope

Name the sustained effort without forcing optimism. — "You have kept showing up for this even though it has been draining."

Direct report missed the target

Hold two truths - the work was real, the result fell short. — "The effort is real, and the result still needs a different approach."

Partner returns after conflict

Name the re-entry, not the resolution. — "I appreciate you coming back to this instead of letting it sit."

Team member's invisible coordination

Make the hidden logistics visible and credit them specifically. — "You absorbed a lot of the setup work that made this easier for everyone."

Burnout risk from heroic effort

Acknowledge the effort, then change the setup. — "This should not take heroic effort every time. Let's change the process."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The effort claim is being used to avoid accountability for harm or poor conduct.
- You do not actually know whether effort was present - you would be guessing.
- The person wants a practical decision, not recognition.
- Recognition would sound patronising because of a power, status, or age gap.
- The same person is repeatedly overburdened and needs resources, not words.
- You are tempted to use acknowledgement to make someone accept unfair work.
- The conversation needs immediate safety, boundary-setting, or concrete action.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the signal

For five minutes, read or imagine short conversation snippets and label the effort signal - preparation, persistence, care, restraint, recovery, cognitive labour, or emotional labour. Do not phrase anything yet; train perception first.

Day 2 — One-sentence formula

Take three of yesterday's signals and write one sentence each using: "You [specific action] despite [constraint], and that [effect] matters." Keep every version to a single sentence.

Day 3 — Effort plus standard

Practise holding two truths. Write three lines that name the effort and keep the standard, e.g. "You prepared carefully, and the client question still needs a clearer answer."

Day 4 — Tone reduction

Take three overdone lines ("I am blown away by how hard you worked") and cut each to something grounded ("I can see the preparation in this"). Remove anything that sounds like flattery or a speech.

Day 5 — Say it aloud

Read your best five lines out loud in a normal voice. Cut any that sound patronising, managerial, or performative. Keep only what you could actually say.

Day 6 — Live rep, low stakes

In one real conversation today, find one genuine effort signal and acknowledge it in a single sentence. Then pause and let it land. Note how it went.

Day 7 — Rep before feedback

In a conversation where you need to give feedback or correction, acknowledge the specific effort first, pause, then move to the next step. Afterwards note: what you perceived, what you said, how it landed, and what you would adjust.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- What specific effort signal did I notice - preparation, persistence, care, restraint, recovery, or labour?
- Was I confident enough to state it plainly, or should I have asked instead?
- Did I acknowledge the effort before advice, correction, evaluation, or moving on?
- Was the phrase specific and one sentence, not a preface to a harsh "but"?
- Did I adjust intensity when they relaxed, deflected, or looked embarrassed?
- When words were not enough, did I separate effort from outcome or change the setup?